

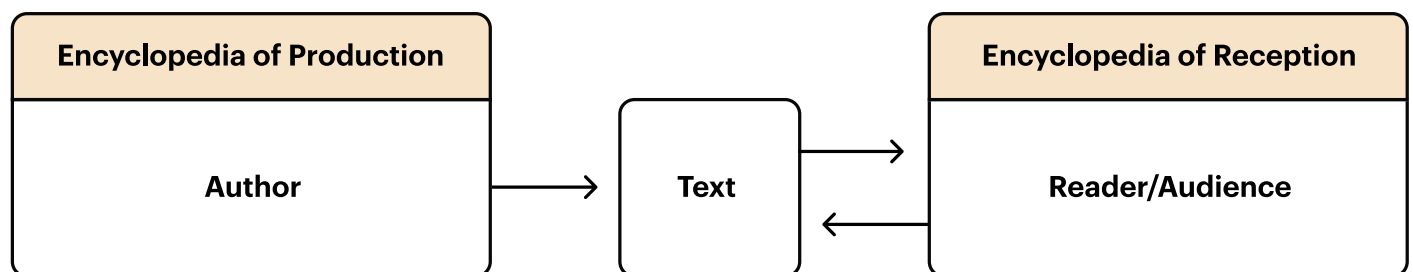
Session 15: Noticing Repeated Words

Key Takeaways

- Although the stories in the Hebrew Bible were written over a long period of time, they are intricately connected to one another.
- The Hebrew Bible is like a quilt where the pieces represent various stories and the thread stitching them together represents repeated words and patterns.
- The point of this quilt of stories replaying and developing the same storyline is for us to see our own lives in these patterns. The stories in the Bible aren't just something we look at—they become what we look through to understand our experiences.

How To Read the Hebrew Scriptures

The Hebrew Bible is an ancient text, and a text is an act of literary communication.



Textual Communication. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

The ideas of our “encyclopedia of production” and “encyclopedia of reception” are from Stefan Alkier’s *Reading the Bible Intertextually*.

Our “encyclopedia” is the mental storehouse of words, ideas, images, and stories that we gather and store in our memories from our first waking moments. Every text we read will be interpreted and understood in light of our current operating encyclopedia. Authors have their encyclopedias from which they produce texts, and readers have encyclopedias through which they process and understand texts.

The model reader who wants to understand an author on their terms will adapt their encyclopedia of reception by learning about the author’s encyclopedia of production.

Where is the meaning located in the text? The text is the literary embodiment of an author’s intended communication.

"[A text-focused approach] sets out to understand not the realities behind the text but the text itself as a pattern of meaning and effect. What does this piece of language ... signify in context? What are the rules governing the transaction between the storyteller or poet and the reader? ... What image of a world does the narrative project? Why does it unfold the action in this particular order and from this particular viewpoint? What is the part played by the omissions, redundancies, ambiguities, alternations between story and summary or elevated and colloquial language? How does the work hang together? In what relationship does each part stand to the whole? To pursue this line of questioning is to make sense of the work as an act of communication, always goal-directed on the writer's part and always requiring interpretive activity on the addressee's. The author wields certain linguistic and literary tools with an eye to certain effects on the reader, while the reader infers a coherent message from the signals, and it is the text itself that mediates between these two, embodying the author's intent and guiding the reader's response."

Sternberg, Meir (1987). [*The Poetics of Biblical Narrative: Ideological Literature and the Drama of Reading*](#). Indiana University Press. 15.

Text vs. Event

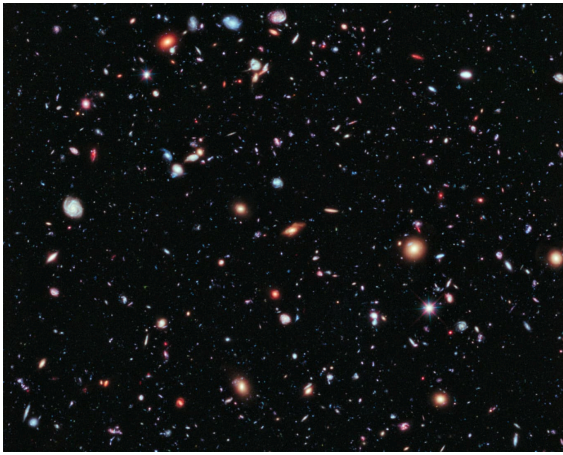
A text provides a literary representation of an object that helps the reader grasp its meaning and significance from a particular perspective.



Magritte, René (1929). *The Treachery of Images*. [Wiki Art](#)

"Ah, the famous pipe. How people reproached me for it! And yet, could you stuff my pipe? No, it's just a representation, is it not? So if I had written on my picture 'This is a pipe,' I'd have been lying!"

Torczyner, Harry (1985). [*Magritte: The True Art of Painting*](#). Abradale/Abrams. 85.



Left: Hubble Telescope (2009). *Hubble Deep Field Image*. ([Wikimedia Commons](#)). Right: van Gogh, Vincent (1889). *The Starry Night*. ([Wikimedia Commons](#)).

Both images are representations of the starry universe portrayed through different media for different purposes, and with different effects on the viewer. Neither one is the starry universe itself ("This is not a pipe."). The Hubble photo represents a maximal realism, while "The Starry Night" employs an impressionistic style. "The Starry Night" conveys the impression and feeling of the night sky as it's relevant to a small human community. It communicates much through minimal detail and uses juxtaposition and contrast (swirling skies vs. geometric human buildings) as well as similarity (blue tones in the sky and on land).

Summary

1. The Hebrew Bible offers a literary representation of Israel's history that claims to be a divinely inspired, prophetic interpretation of Israel's history within the larger context of God's cosmic purposes.
2. The Hebrew Bible is not a history of Israel (or "chronicle of Jonah's exploits"); rather, it is a theological interpretation of Israel's (and Jonah's) story designed to elicit a response from the reader.
3. The Hebrew Bible is a collection of collections, made up of textual materials from all periods of Israel's history, religion, and literature.

Stages in the Process of Making the TaNaK

How does an author make a collection of collections mean something? We must first understand the actual materials used by the biblical authors. The tradition of ancient Israelite literature came into existence through a multi-step process that is still discernible by looking at literary evidence within the texts themselves.

Events



- The life of Abraham, the exodus, the wilderness wanderings, settlement in the land of Canaan, etc.

The Origins of the Bible From a Historical Perspective. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

	Oral Traditions ↘	• The family history of Abraham’s ancestors, the wilderness wanderings • Early songs: Exodus 15, Judges 5, Psalm 29, etc.
	Early Written Traditions ↘	• “This is the scroll of the generations of humanity” (Gen. 5:1) • “The scroll of Jashar” (Josh. 10:13; 2 Sam. 1:18) • “The scroll of the wars of Yahweh” (Num. 21:14)
	Early Collections of Written Traditions ↘	• “The scroll of the deeds of the kings of Israel” (1 Kgs. 14:19, 29, etc.) • “The commentary of the scroll of the kings” (2 Chron. 24:27)
	Proto-Editions of Biblical Books ↘	• “The proverbs of Solomon that the men of Hezekiah compiled” (Prov. 25:1) • “The prayers of David son of Jesse are ended” (Ps. 72:20) • The “Mosaic” Torah (Exod. 21-23 and Deut. 12-26) • First edition of Jeremiah (Jer. 36)
		TaNaK Editions of Biblical Books
The Origins of the Bible From a Historical Perspective. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).		

Each of these stages is worthy of study for historical interest. However, classical orthodox Jewish and Christian theology (i.e., biblical theology) has been based on the final edition of the biblical text, that is, the text of the Hebrew Scriptures in the time of Jesus.

The Family Quilt Metaphor

A quilt made of many preexisting materials can retain the integrity of the earlier materials while giving the new layers meaning when they are set within a larger context and frame of reference.

So now we can ask: What is the matrix of themes and motifs that the author of Jonah assumes we already know?

The Story Behind the Story of Jonah

- Genesis 3-4: Adam, Eve, Cain, and Cain's city of blood
- Genesis 6-11: The generation of the flood and the chosen one (comforter Noah) rescued through the waters to intercede through sacrifice. God relents, but humanity goes on to make another city.
- Genesis 12, 18-19: Abraham brought out of Babylon, intercedes on behalf of Sodom.
- Exodus 2-3, 14-15: God rescues Moses through the waters (in an ark). Moses then meets with God on Sinai (in fire) and is commissioned to confront the king of Egypt. Moses resists but eventually goes. Israel flees and is rescued through the waters on dry land, and they come to fear Yahweh and believe in him.
- Exodus 32-34: God's rescued people make an idol. God threatens to bring a flood of judgment upon them, but Moses steps in to offer intercession, appealing to Abraham and then offering his own life as a sacrifice of atonement. God forgives the people, and Moses sees Yahweh and learns of his character.
- 1 Kings 17-19: In Ahab's sinful generation, God sends Elijah to announce the opposite of a flood (a drought). He leads Israel to meet with God in fire on Mount Carmel, but he is ultimately unsuccessful in turning Israel back to Yahweh. He goes to the wilderness, and instead of interceding and offering himself, he asks God to kill him. Then he goes to Mount Sinai and has a pity party in a dialogue with God. He is an anti-Moses.
- Jeremiah 18, 26: Jeremiah is sent as a prophetic intercessor to Israel to tell them that if they repent, God will relent and not bring disaster. But the Israelites reject him and bring down innocent blood upon themselves.

Core Themes of the TaNaK Found in Jonah

- Humans are violent and destructive and bring the blood guilt of the innocent upon themselves, compelling God to bring judgment.
- God wants to bless humanity instead of destroying them, so he makes and fulfills his promise to rescue humanity by raising up a deliverer/intercessor (Noah, Abraham, Moses, Elijah, Jeremiah) who will appeal to his mercy.
- Human intercessors are problematic, sometimes doing their job (Noah, Abraham, Moses) but other times failing to persuade their audience (Jeremiah) or failing personally (Elijah).
- The portraits of human intercessors point forward to the ultimate prophetic intercessor like Moses.
- The book of Jonah also points forward to this hope (as Jesus understood in Matthew 12:40), but it does so by creating an inverted parody portrait of Jonah as the anti-Moses prophet.

Reflection Question

Although the stories in the Hebrew Bible were written over a long period of time, they are intricately connected to one another. How is this similar or different from how you and those in your context typically view the Bible?